

Name: _____

Date: _____

The First Moon Landing

Grade 5 reading comprehension · Informational text · 13 points · About 25 minutes

A giant leap

On July 16, 1969, a huge Saturn V rocket, about as tall as a 36-story building, lifted off from Florida carrying three astronauts: Neil Armstrong, Buzz Aldrin, and Michael Collins. Their mission, called Apollo 11, had one goal: to land people on the Moon and bring them home safely.

Landing on the Moon

After about four days in space, the spacecraft reached the Moon. Collins stayed in the command ship, Columbia, circling above. Armstrong and Aldrin climbed into a small lander named Eagle. The landing was tricky: with fuel running low, Armstrong took over the controls to steer past a field of boulders. On July 20, Eagle touched down on a flat area called the Sea of Tranquility. Armstrong radioed back to Earth, “The Eagle has landed.”

One small step

Hours later, Armstrong climbed down a ladder and became the first person to walk on the Moon. As he stepped onto the dusty surface, he said, “That’s one small step for man, one giant leap for mankind.” Aldrin joined him soon after. Together they collected rocks, set up science experiments, and planted an American flag. Before they left, they also set down a metal plaque that ends with the words “We came in peace for all mankind.”

Home again

The two men spent about 21 hours on the Moon, and only about two and a half hours of that outside Eagle. They carried about 47 pounds of Moon rocks and soil back inside Eagle. Then they blasted off to meet Collins, and all three astronauts headed back to Earth. On July 24, their capsule splashed down in the Pacific Ocean, where a Navy ship picked them up. As a precaution, the astronauts then stayed in a special quarantine room for about three weeks. Hundreds of millions of people had watched the landing on television.

1. What was the goal of the Apollo 11 mission? (1 point)

2. Who stayed in the command ship, Columbia, while the others landed? (1 point)

3. Copy the exact words Armstrong said when the lander touched down. Use quotation marks. (2 points)

4. What does the word “mission” mean in the first section? (1 point)

5. What did Armstrong say as he stepped onto the Moon? Quote his words exactly. (2 points)

6. Collins never walked on the Moon. Why was he still important to the mission? Use evidence from the text. (2 points)

7. Number these events 1 to 4 in the order they happen. (2 points)

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The capsule splashes down in the Pacific Ocean.

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Armstrong steps onto the Moon.

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The Saturn V rocket lifts off from Florida.

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Eagle touches down on the Sea of Tranquility.

8. Summarize the text in two sentences. (2 points)

Writing task: Imagine you are Armstrong or Aldrin. Write a journal entry about your first hours on the Moon.
